

Illinois - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-30 underlying quality with a stable quarterback/leadership core but substantial two-sided turnover
Preseason consensus	AP unranked, 9 points (others receiving votes) · SP+ No. 28
Returning production	51% (No. 72) overall · Off. 53% (No. 72) · Def. 49% (No. 80)
Primer power rating	+10.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.1 wins · most likely 7-5
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar quality, lower continuity and likely more volatility
Confidence	Medium

2026 identity: Illinois remains an efficiency-first team built around experienced QB Katin Houser, a veteran reconstructed OL and a committee backfield. New DC Bobby Hauck shifts the defense to an aggressive 3-3-5 around DB Matthew Bailey, DB Xavier Scott and CB Juice Clarke; the question is whether imported experience can replace a large NFL/transfer exit class without losing the 2025 efficiency floor.

Bottom line: Illinois still profiles as a strong top-30 Power 4 team, but lower returning production, a new defensive system and heavy veteran replacement make another nine-win season less bankable.

Beats expectations if: QB Houser preserves top-25 efficiency, the transfer-heavy OL coheres quickly and Hauck creates more negative plays without sacrificing elite explosive prevention.

Disappoints if: OL/front continuity breaks down, WR Hudson Clement and thin TE/WR depth stay compromised, and the new defense loses 2025's big-play prevention.

Five things to remember

- 2025 baseline:** QB Katin Houser is an established current starter and team captain with 26 career starts and 3,300 passing yards at East Carolina in 2025.
- 2025 baseline:** Illinois' 2025 offense was top-25 by opponent-adjusted rating, EPA/play and success rate even though total offense ranked only No. 80.
- Coaching:** New DC Bobby Hauck is installing an aggressive 3-3-5 and is explicitly confirmed as the defensive play caller from the box.
- Secondary:** The secondary still has DB Matthew Bailey, DB Xavier Scott and CB Juice Clarke, but the defense must replace major losses including OLB Gabe Jacas, DL James Thompson Jr. and DB Miles Scott while returning only 49% of production (No. 80).
- Schedule pressure:** SP+ projects 7.1 wins against the No. 25 schedule, with Ohio State and Oregon as the two biggest ceiling blockers and a large middle class of tossup-to-small-edge games.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	9-4 (5-4 Big Ten)	● Good
Scoring	29.4 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	373.8 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	138.1 YPG · 3.9 YPC	● Below average
Pass efficiency	8.24 YPA · 23 TD / 6 INT	● Very good
Third downs	42.4%	● Good / above average
Scoring defense	23.6 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	344.9 YPG allowed	● Good / above average
Rush defense	126.5 YPG · 3.9 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass defense	218.4 YPG · 6.62 YPA · 19 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

Illinois paired modest raw offensive volume with strong passing efficiency and third-down work. The defense was solid overall, especially against the run, with more ordinary scoring and pass-efficiency results.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+4.68 · No. 25	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.112 · No. 25	● Very good
Off. success rate	47.6% · No. 23	● Very good
Off. explosive-play rate	12.5% · No. 58	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	15.9% · No. 85	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	+2.47 · No. 42	● Good / above average
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.041 · No. 46	● Good / above average
Def. success rate allowed	44.4% · No. 108	● Poor
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	7.3% · No. 5	● Elite
Havoc created	15.4% · No. 73	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: The offense’s top-25 opponent-adjusted rating, EPA/play and success rate outpaced its raw yardage rank. The defense was elite at preventing explosives but poor by success rate, winning more by limiting damage than by controlling every down.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Bret Bielema - returning	● ↔ Program continuity supports a stable baseline around an experienced core.
OC	Barry Lunney Jr. - returning; exact game-day play-calling authority remains unresolved	● ↔ Offensive continuity is valuable, but exact game-day play-calling authority remains unresolved.
DC / defensive play caller	◆ Bobby Hauck - from Montana HC; confirmed defensive caller from the box	● ↔ The new 3-3-5 adds transition risk but a clear defensive call structure.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Katin Houser	East Carolina	● ↔ Experienced 26-start quarterback gives Illinois a credible replacement for QB Luke Altmyer rather than a developmental reset.
◆ C Jake Renfro	Wisconsin	● ↑ Captain/Rimington-watch center is the anchor of the reconstructed line.
◆ OL Christian Martin	Colorado State	● ↔ Projects at left tackle and adds college experience to a heavily rebuilt line.
◆ WR Jayshon Platt	Florida Atlantic	● ↔ Biletnikoff-watch transfer adds needed major-role depth around WR Collin Dixon and WR Hudson Clement.

Out	To	Loss
QB Luke Altmyer	NFL (Detroit), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Veteran starting quarterback departs, making QB Houser's transition central to the offense.
OL J.C. Davis	NFL (N.Y. Giants), Round 6, No. 192	● ↓ Drafted tackle/line starter is a major continuity loss.
WR Hank Beatty	NFL (Tennessee), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Major veteran receiving/return production exits an already reshaped WR room.
OL Josh Gesky	NFL (Green Bay), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Another veteran line departure increases dependence on the transfer rebuild.
TE Cole Rusk	Arizona	● ↓ TE departure matters more after BJ Thurman's major injury and Tanner Arkin's pro exit.

Offensive net: ● ↔ roughly similar at the top, but with materially less continuity and thinner TE/WR depth.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL Darrell Prater	Jacksonville State	● ↔ Major interior role candidate in a rebuilt front, but not a proven replacement for the full veteran exit class.
◆ LB Robert Edmonson	Colorado State	● ↔ Adds experienced linebacker rotation depth in the new 3-3-5.
◆ DB James Finley IV	Northern Illinois	● ↔ Provides another major secondary option around DB Bailey, DB Scott and DB Clarke.

Out	To	Loss
OLB Gabe Jacas	NFL (New England), Round 2, No. 55	● ↓ Second-round edge/OLB departure is the largest individual loss on defense.
DL James Thompson Jr.	NFL (San Francisco), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Veteran defensive-line production leaves the front.
DB Miles Scott	NFL (Denver), Round 7, No. 246	● ↓ Drafted secondary contributor departs, reducing the cushion around the returning anchors.
DT Angelo McCullom	Texas A&M	● ↓ Material interior transfer loss compounds the professional front turnover.
DL Tomiwa Durojaiye	South Carolina	● ↓ Another material defensive-line departure adds replacement burden.

Defensive net: ● ↓ worse composition, especially in the front, with the veteran secondary limiting the downside.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Efficiency-first attack built around experience rather than pure explosiveness.	QB Katin Houser, RB Ca'Lil Valentine, RB Aidan Laughery and a C Jake Renfro-led OL fit the 2025 top-25 efficiency profile.	WR/TE attrition and a rebuilt line shrink the passing margin if WR Hudson Clement is limited.
Defense	Aggressive 3-3-5 under DC Bobby Hauck, with the strongest proven talent in the secondary.	DB Matthew Bailey, DB Xavier Scott and CB Juice Clarke support continued explosive prevention.	Front-seven turnover and a No. 108 success-rate defense demand more negative plays without opening big-play cracks.
Special teams	Solid baseline with a live kicker competition.	SP+ special teams is No. 30 and P Lars Rau is projected to punt.	Placekicker remains unsettled after the prior starter transferred.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B	● ↔	High	QB Houser brings 26 starts and captain status, but still replaces a proven veteran starter.
RB	● B	● ↔	High	RB Valentine and RB Laughery provide a stable top rotation.
WR	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	WR Dixon and WR Platt are credible, but WR Clement is health-limited and WR Perry is likely out.
TE	● C	● ↓	Low	TE Cole Rusk and another veteran are gone, while an injury further thins an unsettled room.
OL	● B	● ↔	Medium	C Jake Renfro anchors an experienced transfer-heavy five with little shared continuity.
DL/Edge	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	Major front losses leave DL Darrell Prater and the rebuilt rotation replacing proven production.
LB	● B–	● ↔	Medium	LB Robert Edmonson joins a workable group that still must absorb front-seven turnover.
Secondary	● B+	● ↔	High	DB Bailey, DB Xavier Scott, DB Clarke and DB Finley can preserve a real strength.
Special teams	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	The model baseline is solid, but kicker remains unsettled.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	Bielema and Lunney provide continuity while Hauck brings experience into a new defensive system.
Overall	● B+	● ↔	Medium	SP+ No. 28 signals top-30 quality, but lower continuity and front/skill replacement cap confidence.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: preseason honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Katin Houser (TR: East Carolina)	QB	● Solid-to-high-end Power 4 starter projection	-	Team captain with 26 career starts and 3,300 passing yards at ECU in 2025; the cleanest answer to Illinois' largest offensive departure.
Matthew Bailey	DB	● High-end conference defensive leader	Bednarik watchlist	Team captain who led Illinois in tackles in 2025 and anchors the secondary in the new 3-3-5.
Xavier Scott	DB	● High-end conference starter / comeback anchor	Comeback Player of the Year watch list	Captain returning after 2025 injury/redshirt with prior first-team All-Big Ten context.
Jake Renfro (TR: Wisconsin)	C	● High-end veteran center projection	Rimington watchlist	Captain and centerpiece of a rebuilt line that must replace multiple professional departures.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Ca'Lil Valentine	RB	● Above-average conference rotation back	Doak Walker watchlist	Returning lead-volume back in a committee with captain Aidan Laughery.
Collin Dixon	WR	● Established conference starter	-	Leading returning receiver (35 catches, 548 yards, five TDs) and a team captain in a room dealing with injuries and turnover.
Jayshon Platt (TR: Florida Atlantic)	WR	● High-upside transfer receiver	Biletnikoff watchlist	FAU transfer adds needed upside and depth around Dixon/Clement.
Juice Clarke	CB	● High-end returning corner	2025 All-Big Ten honorable mention	One of the proven secondary pieces charged with preserving Illinois' elite explosive-play prevention.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Hard enough to suppress the 2025 win total, with Ohio State and Oregon creating two near-automatic high-end tests and a long middle tier of genuine swing games
Difficulty	● 8/10 · Very hard · SP+ SOS No. 25
Hardest stretch	at Ohio State → Purdue → at Michigan State → Oregon (bye before Oregon)
Swing games	Duke, at Michigan State, at Maryland, Nebraska, at UCLA, Iowa, at Northwestern
Advantage	Three straight home games open the season, and the bye falls immediately before Oregon.
Expected	7.1 wins · most likely 7-5
Floor / ceiling	5-7 / 9-3

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The 9-4 record and Bielema stability support respect, but No. 72 returning production and a large exit class argue against pricing in 2025-level continuity.
Back them when	Against mid-tier opponents when QB Houser and the veteran OL are intact, especially against offenses dependent on explosives.
Fade/pass when	Laying a premium before the rebuilt front, TE/WR depth and new 3-3-5 have proven stable, or when the matchup requires Illinois to trade explosive scores with an elite offense.
Key monitor	WR Hudson Clement availability, kicker winner, OL cohesion, front-seven rotation, DB Xavier Scott return, exact offensive game-day play caller
Week 1 baseline	Illinois -30.0 vs. UAB · early rating-based fair value; compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Illinois -28.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Illinois has top-30 underlying quality and a credible efficiency floor behind QB Katin Houser, an experienced rebuilt OL and a veteran secondary. The roster is talented enough to stay in the Big Ten’s upper middle despite major turnover.

The risk is continuity: both lines are being reconstructed, the skill depth is thinner and DC Bobby Hauck is changing the defensive structure. Seven wins is a sound center, with upside if the imported experience settles quickly.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [captains](#) · [DC Bobby Hauck](#) · [defensive identity](#) · [depth and injuries](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [kicking battle](#)

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